



**Mother and baby homes (including
pre-1948 Workhouses) and
Magdalene laundries oral history
project**

Interview with CO

CO Transcript

CO

Date: 2nd March 2019

Location: England

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Pete Hodson

CO was interviewed in England. Her mother was born in Northern Ireland and gave birth to a daughter in a workhouse in 194*. CO explained what she has been able to find out about the circumstances surrounding the birth. It was only in recent years that CO became aware that she had a half-sister who was trying to trace their shared birth mother. To protect the identity of CO and her family members, names are anonymised or redacted as are exact locations and dates. Redactions are indicated by **.

OD: Okay, perfect. So just for the tape to test, my name is Olivia Dee and we...I've come to England to interview an anonymous interviewee about her mother's experiences of *location redacted* workhouse. The date is the 2nd of March 2019, we're going to kind of start with a few questions and talk about the experiences of your mother?

CO: Okay.

OD: You have mentioned to me that you – your mother – is unwell with dementia.

CO: Yes. She's still alive at ninety-two, but has advanced dementia.

OD: Yep. So, we're kind of talking about some memories that she has in kind of more lucid moments, or things that you've discovered through P.R.O.N.I. [Public Records Office Northern Ireland], and things that you've been shown, kind of, by social workers in Northern Ireland.

CO: That's right. I would just like to say before we begin that I'm my mum's legal representative under the Mental Capacity Act and I would like to give her a voice by participating in this interview.

OD: And I really appreciate that. Okay, great. So, can I start first of all, then, by asking you how you initially sort of came across the fact that your mother had been in *location redacted*? I know we've sort of discussed it a little bit already, but...

CO: Well, it started with an email from my cousin in Ireland who told me that she'd been told by another relative that somebody had been searching for my mum ten years ago, thinking that she might also be her biological mother.

OD: Wow.

CO: Now I didn't really think there was anything to it, but I thought I'd follow it up just in case because, really, everybody should know their mother. So, somehow, they had her birth certificate, which they sent me.

OD: They had her birth certificate.

CO: They had her birth certificate. Now they've kept very quiet about how that

all happened. A relative just said: “Well that’s confidential and I don’t want to get anybody into trouble.” So, it was all very secretive.

OD: Yeah.

CO: But nevertheless, they did send it to me.

OD: So, you found that you had a potential relative who also kind of thought that – well, had sort of gone through the tracing process and thought that she may have found her mother, and that was your...

CO: Yes.

OD: ...mother.

CO: Yes, but I didn’t know how sure she was. In my attempt to find her I contacted quite a few organisations – Family Placement Teams, the infirmary where she was born, which is now a hospital. I added myself to the Adoption Register, wrote to the Public Record Office in Northern Ireland to see if they could do a partial search on the information I had from the certificate (but they couldn’t do that). I also contacted the Catholic Church where I guessed she had been baptised. They didn’t answer.

OD: Which church do you think she was baptised in?

CO: St *name redacted* Catholic Church in *location redacted*. They’ve actually been quite helpful since I found her.

OD: Yeah.

CO: But not helpful in providing information that might have helped me find her. I also contacted the *location in England redacted* Adoption Service to see if they would help, but they said they didn't have the resources or the budget, and they could only offer counselling if I tracked her down.

OD: Right.

CO: Which wasn't really what I wanted.

OD: Yeah.

CO: A cousin helped me with the search – the one that told me the story in the first place. She worked very hard in Ireland to try and dig up whatever she could. I also pestered my relatives in NI for information and gained the reputation for being a bloodhound and a woodpecker.

OD: So, can I ask a question there? I just want to clarify it before we move on. So, were you finding your mother yourself, or had you grown up with her?

CO: My sister, my half-sister, you mean?

OD: No, you?

CO: Oh my mother?

OD: Yeah?

CO: Yeah. I'd grown up with her, yeah.

OD: So, you'd stayed with her and the sister hadn't, and that was the situation?

CO: Yeah, the half-sister hadn't...My mum went on to have five more children.

OD: Okay.

CO: So she got married five years after her first child.

OD: Got it. And are you the first, you're the first child?

CO: I'm the middle of the five.

OD: Middle of the five, okay.

CO: But that all changed. Which is actually quite an odd thing when you've always grown up thinking you're the middle child of five and then you find actually you're not. It's a slightly weird feeling.

OD: I can imagine, and just...I think the addition of any family member is kind of bizarre, but a sibling is even more...

CO: Yeah. Everybody gets slightly displaced.

OD: Yeah.

CO: From who they thought they were.

OD: Especially the oldest and the youngest, I suppose?

CO: Yeah.

OD: So, thank you for the clarification. So then, you were trying to clarify this sister and her position in your family? So, what happens next?

CO: What happened next was I got a letter from NI Direct government services who informed me there had been a match on the adoption register. Now I have to say, when I filled in the adoption contact register form I had to declare myself a relative even though I wasn't 100% sure that I was. I wasn't given another option. My half-sister was given the option of saying 'To the best of my knowledge'.

OD: But you weren't?

CO: No, I was left in this sort of catch-22 situation. I either had to go ahead and do that - declaring myself a relative without 100% certainty - or not fill it in and never find her. So that wasn't a very nice position to be put in. But the registrar required a number of certificates from me and had to be satisfied that there was a relationship. So, I decided to go ahead and take that risk. So, then, we got notified of the match, and then I didn't actually hear from her for a month.

OD: Right?

CO: Apparently, somebody had written to my mum 10 years previously on my half-sister's behalf and followed it up with a phone call... My mum said that she was sorry but she couldn't help, because she didn't know who she was. Now my mum had the early stages of dementia then. So, I think one of two things happened: either she had dementia related amnesia – I did a video

interview with her slightly after that where she couldn't remember where she was born— or she had traumatic amnesia.

OD: Yeah.

CO: Because I think if her daughter had come looking for her, she would have welcomed her.

OD: Yeah, I think so.

CO: Yeah.

OD: See that's really interesting. So, there'd already been that contact and...

CO: Yeah. We didn't know anything about that.

OD: And do you think...so why do you think your mum didn't tell you? Do you think that was to do with...

CO: Well, actually she did tell me. She told me that somebody had phoned. She said this lady had phoned – no, sorry, had written to her – maybe both written and phoned - and she said she was looking for her mother, and could she help her. Mum told me she felt sorry for her, but she didn't know who she was. So, I just thought somebody's scamming her, you know? She'd already been scammed for holiday money, so I didn't really take any notice because I didn't even think for a moment she had another child – let alone that she had one that she'd forgotten about.

OD: Yeah. Definitely.

CO: So, yeah... I vaguely remember the telephone conversation with my mum and then just kind of dismissing it really.

OD: Yeah, let it go? And there's so many scam phone calls now isn't there?

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: I can imagine that was just...

CO: And I think it was the language as well. "Can you help?" - to my ears sounded like "can you give me money?"

OD: Yeah. That's interesting. So, what happened next?

CO: So, then I waited for a whole month for my half-sister to get in touch. She didn't know her mum was still alive at this point. She was adopted and both her [adoptive] parents had been dead a long time. Her [adoptive] father died when she was three, and then her [adoptive] mother died when she was about twenty-two. So, she was nearly fifty years without any parents.

OD: Wow.

CO: So, she would have already been upset that her mother didn't respond to the request for help.

OD: Yeah.

CO: And made the assumption that her mother didn't want to know her. So,

then this potential half-sister (me) has contacted her, but does she really want to know now having already felt rejected ten years previously? I don't know. We haven't had that conversation, but she got a shock. And then she got another one when I told her that her mother was still alive – and then she got another one when I told her mum had five more children. So, it took time, you know, step-by-step, to get through the process. She didn't have any counselling. I didn't have any counselling – actually didn't need any.

OD: Yeah.

CO: It was fine.

OD: Some people don't. I think it's...you never know how it's going to affect people individually.

CO: No.

OD: And I suppose...I dunno. I think it's really amazing that you did so much of that work to find her because I think, I dunno, that's quite a lot to take on isn't it? Especially if your mum's unwell.

CO: Yeah. I mean it was a whole project and it's quite hard to get help as well.

OD: Definitely.

CO: Particularly during the search process. And then there was another whole digging up process after that to find out more.

OD: So once you'd kind of met your sister was that – or your half-sister – was

that when you decided that you wanted to learn more about where your mother had come from, or where...Or was it more your sister who wanted to find out?

CO: No, no. She seems quite happy just to take things as they are, whereas I tend to want to dig and dig and dig.

OD: Are you a historian?

CO: I'm not, actually, no.

OD: You sound like an historian.

CO: Only if I'm interested enough.

OD: Yeah.

CO: But then what happened after that was I suggested a DNA test because I still wasn't convinced that she was my half-sister although I think she was.

OD: And did you get that?

CO: Well, that was quite difficult.

OD: Yeah, I was imagining...

CO: So, I got written family consent; I got care home approval. The British Medical Association wouldn't touch it with a bargepole. The care staff weren't allowed to take a swab, so I took the swab. And then I had problems with the lab and had a lengthy email exchange with them over the Human Tissue Act.

And then eventually the Citizens Advice website helped resolve it.

OD: Really?

CO: The lab asked for certain conditions to be met – e.g. that the care home manager said it was in her best interests etc.

OD: Definitely.

CO: So that's how I got through that. So, then, I sent her the DNA test kit in the post and the lab result came back positive for maternity. No question. 99.9999%.

OD: Wow.

CO: Yeah.

OD: And how did you feel about that?

CO: Shocked. I was shaking, yeah. So, I just sent her the email from the lab and said, you know, I think we should both have a bit of time to absorb this, and then sent it out to the other family members.

OD: And how were they? Were they quite receptive or...

CO: Well I think we were all in a bit of shock.

OD: Yeah.

CO: To be honest. Yeah.

OD: So that's five siblings she found that she had without...

CO: Yeah. Well one had died, so she hasn't met her, but she looks just like her – which is weird.

OD: That is weird.

CO: Yeah. And she appeared within one day of the anniversary of my younger sister's death, looking like her, so that was weird as well. And her name...can I say what her name is?

OD: Yeah. It'll be taken out of the transcript, but yeah.

CO: Yeah. Okay. *half-sister's name redacted*.

OD: Oh no. Oh wow.

CO: Yeah.

OD: That must have been...wow.

CO: But she calls herself *name redacted*, but that was the name that was...

OD: Oh, that would've made me a bit shaky too, I think?

CO: Yeah, yeah. It just gets weirder and weirder.

OD: I'm just thinking about...because I only have one brother and the idea that suddenly someone else comes into that? It must just throw everything into a bit of kind of strangeness? And then...

CO: Yeah.

OD: So how did you kind of come back from that? Did you meet to talk about it, or...

CO: Yeah. I suggested we meet, and we met at the care home just in *name of town redacted* actually, because I've moved my mum up to *name of town redacted*.

OD: Good.

CO: And it did feel a bit like an episode of *Long Lost Family*. So, I couldn't stop looking at her and she was very emotional, but she held it together quite well.

OD: And how was your mum at this point?

CO: Mum was oblivious but in a good mood, so she was in a smiley mood. The manageress took – intercepted us – before we went in so she could talk to *half-sister's name redacted* about mum and what her, you know, realistic expectation should be. So, it was good, but I was like “hurry up because she's in a good mood.”

OD: Well maybe she knew in some way, then, I don't know? Maybe...

CO: Yeah. Well, I think that as well. I think at some level she knows, yeah.

OD: I'm trying...I mean I don't, obviously, don't know the details of it but I suppose if she's in a good mood and if that happens and she maybe looks like one of her daughters, it must have...

CO: And she does look a bit like my mum as well.

OD: That's nice.

CO: She looks more like my mum than I do. And she's five foot nothing, no sense of direction, so she kind of fitted right in 'cos we're all like that.

OD: That's...I mean it's a very emotional thing, but it must have been...

CO: Weird. Bizarre, yeah. I mean she's a seventy-one year old woman, comes into our lives who we're related to by blood? I mean it's...

OD: I think that's the other thing about this as well, isn't it, is that the age...Everyone always sort of thinks that these reunion things happen, you know, when people are still kind of young, in their twenties and trying to...But actually, you know, sometimes like you said they go fifty years without, without trying to contact or without having that kind of...

CO: Well she didn't know she was adopted until she got to sixty.

OD: Oh really?

CO: Yeah.

OD: So, they hadn't, they'd chosen not to tell her?

CO: And she had asked as well because her mother was, I think, forty-three when she 'had the baby'.

OD: Wow.

CO: And as I said her dad died very young. And nobody – one of the things she said – nobody said she looked like anyone.

OD: Yeah.

CO: So that was quite emotional for her.

OD: And then to turn into a family where she looks like everyone?

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Gosh, that's a really amazing story. So how did that meeting go? Your mum was, you said, oblivious but happy?

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: So...

CO: So, it went as well as it could and then we went to the pub and met one of my other sisters.

OD: Wow. So, what did you decide to do from that point onwards? Was it kind of...was she, did she want to become part of that family?

CO: Yeah. We meet up every couple of months.

OD: Wow, that's amazing.

CO: Yeah, so we tend to meet here because this is where mum is, and we meet up with other family members.

OD: And has your mum shown any recognition to her at all?

CO: Well she doesn't, to be honest, she doesn't really know who I am – and I go every day.

OD: Yeah.

CO: So...occasionally she'll get it right, you know, when I'm leaving she'll say 'Cheerio, *interviewee's name redacted*. But actually, everybody is called the same name by mum in the care home.

OD: Definitely.

CO: But she does at some level recognise people, and I think she would know that she was related to that lady who came and sat down at their first meeting. I did straightforwardly say, "a very special lady has come to see you today. Her name is *redacted* and she's your daughter."

OD: Wow.

CO: So, I don't know how much of that she took in?

OD: That's...it just adds another...

CO: Yeah.

OD: ...kind of layer of difficulty, I suppose, to the...

CO: But I thought it was important for *half-sister's name redacted*, as well, to say that – to acknowledge...

OD: I think that's really lovely. And I think you're right, she probably did recognise it in some way. Wow.

CO: And we exchange quite a lot of photos, so she saw photos of mum with the five...So she had five children in six years.

OD: Wow.

CO: She said that one really made her feel emotional.

OD: And what photographs does she have of her mother that she's managed to...did she have anything when she found out that she was adopted? Was there any, like, folder or anything for her?

CO: No, not until I sent her...When we got the DNA test results, about an hour after that I sent her a photo of her mum.

OD: That must have meant a lot to her?

CO: Yeah, she kissed it. And then I think she cried when I sent the one of the five children with her.

OD: Yeah.

CO: Because she felt she should have been there – and I kind of felt that, as well, actually, when I looked at it: God, there's somebody missing now.

OD: So what do you know about the reason that she wasn't kept, or that she was put up for adoption? Do you know anything about that?

CO: Well, all I know is at that time, if you were pregnant and single that was not a good idea.

OD: And this is 194*?

CO: 194*.

OD: 194*. And do you know anything about the pregnancy, or...

CO: Like what, sorry?

OD: Do you know, you know, how she got pregnant? Who she was pregnant with?

CO: Oh, who the father is...No. No. I still ask. I've got a couple of names that

my cousin gave me when I went over to Northern Ireland – a couple of her suitors, but I don't think *half-sister's name redacted* is too bothered about finding out who the father is actually.

OD: No, just the mother? And there's no guarantee that he would be alive or...

CO: Almost certainly he wouldn't be, no.

OD: Okay, so how did your mother end up in the workhouse?

CO: Well, that's a good question.

OD: Oh, of course, do you know how your mother ended up in the workhouse?

CO: Well, apart from the fact unmarried mothers were regarded as no better than criminals and prostitutes at the time – and also judged as mentally unstable – there won't have been many places for her to go. She was living in *location redacted* at the time and she did have a sister in *same location redacted*, so you'd have hoped that she would have taken her in. But apparently not.

OD: Yeah.

CO: But I'm reluctant to judge on that because I don't know what the situation was. And I think that sister had lost a baby herself through an accident, so she may not have been in any fit state of mind...

OD: Yeah.

CO: ...to deal with her.

OD: And what...how old was your mother? I'm trying to do the maths.

CO: She was nineteen.

OD: Nineteen.

CO: Yeah.

OD: So, we know she was nineteen, in *location redacted*, and found herself pregnant?

CO: Yeah.

OD: Did her family kick her out? Like father and mother, or...

CO: The father was dead already.

OD: Okay.

CO: A social worker from Northern Ireland asked me: "Did your mother go back to Ireland to visit her mother?" And I said: "She did."

OD: Okay.

CO: So, she said: "Well, almost certainly she wouldn't have known then." She said: "It wouldn't have been unusual not to have gone back to see your mother for months at a time": because transport wasn't what it is now.

OD: Yeah, definitely.

CO: So yeah, my mum did regularly go back to see her mother. She never lived in Northern Ireland again, though.

With regard to the workhouse: I went to get something from mum's room in the care home and she said: "Don't leave me in the poorhouse on my own." So, when I came back I said: "Were you in the poorhouse, mum?" "Yes", she said, angrily. "What was it like?" I asked. And she said four things:

1. "They was screaming with the pain." Now I assume that was a reference to childbirth? I'm not sure they gave them painkillers?

OD: No, I don't think so.

CO: No. I think they were quite cruel.

2. And this was something that really affected me – "They put me in with the lunatics. I'm not mad." At first, I just thought that she meant that there were people who were mentally ill in there as well. But I think it's a bit more sinister than that, because people who had mild intellectual – or learning difficulties – were regarded by the examining psychiatrist on admission as insane, and I think they did actually put her in the lunatic ward.

OD: Does your mother have any learning difficulties, or anything that might have...

CO: [After reflecting on this question her answer was]: She probably had mild cognitive impairment. She found it difficult to follow the plot on TV

programmes, regularly got the wrong end of the stick and was master of the non-sequitur but she was also great conversationalist and competent shop worker and even held the position of Manageress at one shop. She also had high levels of anxiety. When the telephone rang it would often elicit a "Jesus, Mary and Joseph!" followed sometimes by dire predictions: "*name of son redacted* has been knocked off his bike".

OD: Interesting. So maybe there was no care taken with her? It was just...

OD: ...put her in with the...wow.

CO: She also said: 3. "It nearly destroyed me". And 4. "I didn't want to give it up."

OD: Oh.

CO: And I presume she's talking about the baby? But the baby was taken off her. Two days after she gave birth, the baby was baptised at St *name redacted* Church in *location redacted*.

OD: And how do you know that?

CO: Because *half-sister's name redacted* told me.

OD: Right.

CO: And so I can only assume, from that, that the baby was probably taken off her at birth.

OD: Especially if she...and I'm assuming...

CO: She's not going to have her for two days, is she?

OD: And she wasn't there, I'm assuming? I don't know how we would know this, but whether or not she attended her christening, or if the baby was just taken and christened?

CO: I don't know, but my mum's a Catholic and the family that adopted her are Catholic. Then I got to see the records.

OD: Baptismal records?

CO: Adoption records.

OD: Oh?

CO: Even though I was told by several people that I wouldn't.

OD: Wow.

CO: I did actually manage to get to see them. That's the other thing that I went to Northern Ireland for that I couldn't remember earlier.

OD: And how did you get to see them?

CO: I went to *location redacted* Courthouse. How did I get to see them?
Right. Let me just check.

OD: So, you went to *location redacted* Courthouse?

CO: I went to *location redacted* Courthouse and made an arrangement in advance to view them. I could see that my mum had signed away her parental rights the same month that she gave birth, and that a Catholic priest was involved in the process and acted as Guardian Ad Litem for the adoptive parents.

OD: Which suggests that she didn't know who the...

CO: There was no father on the certificate.

OD: Okay. Do you know the name of the priest? ... Father *name redacted*. So, he was signed as the guardian...

CO: *Ad litem*, yeah.

OD: Interesting, yeah.

CO: I've got the name of the solicitors that were involved as well. So, it was a proper court case.

OD: Yeah.

CO: They were doing it all legally, I suppose. Because often it was done informally, I think, wasn't it; the adoption?

OD: Yeah. So, there was a...it was a legal, a legal...

CO: Yeah, there didn't seem to be any particular reason given. Yeah. I read through it twice to see if I could find anything. So, I think she probably had no money, or she wouldn't have been in the workhouse if she'd had any money.

OD: And I suppose, as well, you wonder if that signing away your parental rights that close to a birth...

CO: Yeah. It shouldn't be allowed.

OD: No, I mean that's obviously going to...if you're panicking and you don't have money and someone's telling you...

CO: And you've been put in the lunatics' ward.

OD: Yeah, and it maybe a way that you can get out and leave and...

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: ...I can imagine it's not a fair way to...

CO: It's not a choice.

OD: No.

CO: No.

OD: And however much you can claim you gave someone a choice you can wonder if that's the case there, in 194*? Okay. So, your...I mean how did you feel when you heard that? Because that came out of nowhere to, you know,

“don’t leave me in the poorhouse” came out of nowhere? I just wondered how that made you feel?

CO: Finding out that she’d been in the workhouse made me feel a bit like I didn’t know her. And it was very sad, you know, that she’d been through that and been silent about it...

OD: Yeah.

CO: ...all those years, you know? All her life. But I don’t know if my dad would’ve known – probably not. She probably would have been told, you know, not to tell anyone.

OD: Yeah, I would think so.

CO: Silence plays a big part in all of this.

OD: I think it did – and guilt and shame and trying to make women feel that it was better to hide that in order to kind of meet someone...

CO: Yeah.

OD: ...and have children in marriage and things like that. I can imagine that must have been really hard.

CO: Yeah, they dumped all the shame on the women and yet, really, where did it belong?

OD: Well, there’s no man on the birth certificate or...

CO: Yeah.

OD: ...the adoption records, so they kind of get away with it don't they?

CO: Yeah. But what about the state, the church, the family...

OD: Yep.

CO: ...and the pathetic excuses for men who have taken no responsibility and have never been held to account.

OD: Yeah. That's why, I mean, the stories of the women are coming forward and absent from all of these stories is what happened to the men who were involved, and that's just something that never gets recorded.

CO: No.

OD: So you have some beautifully typed notes here – I was wondering what happened next?

CO: So...the workhouse, the baby's baptised two days later. The admissions records are missing from the workhouse from, I think it's 194* to 1948 when it shut – or it got taken over by the N.H.S. or something.

OD: Did they give you any reason for that?

CO: No.

OD: Okay.

CO: No. They said they might turn up.

OD: Who said that?

CO: The Public Records Office.

OD: Public Records, okay.

CO: My cousin sent me a photo of mum in 194* where she was smiling at her sister's wedding. So, I'm hoping she was out rather than just let out for the day – because they were let out for the day sometimes as well, I think?

OD: And that's 194* you say?

CO: Yeah. So, I'm hoping when she had the baby that she did get out and wasn't transferred to a laundry. I don't know when the laundries started in Northern Ireland?

OD: They were started by then.

CO: They were, yeah?

OD: It just depends where. I mean there were several.

CO: Yeah. Because I've got these missing years between when she had the baby and when she married my dad, and I don't know where she was.

OD: When did she marry your dad?

CO: Where?

OD: When?

CO: '51 I think it was.

OD: So, you've got...

CO: And in *English city/name redacted*.

OD: She got married in *English city/name redacted*?

CO: She got married in *English city/name redacted*, yeah.

OD: Interesting.

CO: So yeah, exactly, so...

OD: So, you would wonder, if she had gone to a laundry, where she would have met your father and gone to *English city/name redacted*? Or where she would've gone to *English city/name redacted* unless she'd run away?

CO: Well, this social worker in Northern Ireland that I spoke to, I think it was her told me that, you know, they got help to leave the country. They'd got some sort of assistance to go to England...

OD: If they were...

CO: ...that there were organisations that helped these women.

OD: Leave the laundries or leave in general?

CO: Don't know. Can't remember exactly, but...

OD: Interesting. That's really interesting.

CO: So yeah, so I've written down here: 'Was she forced or helped to get to England?' And, you know, are we actually in England because she was judged to be a fallen woman in 194*. It rewrites your own history as well. I often wondered why did my parents not stay in Northern Ireland? They were so Irish, you know. They didn't ever really fit in this culture.

OD: So your father was Irish, not English?

CO: He was born and brought up a few miles from her.

OD: You see that's interesting because that makes you think, perhaps, she got out of the workhouse, met him and came here?

CO: I think she knew him from when she was very young.

OD: Yeah. Rather than going to a laundry because it would be very difficult for her to have met him?

CO: But then men wouldn't touch these women with bargepoles would they?

OD: Maybe your dad was a nice...

CO: Maybe.

OD: ...a much nicer man?

CO: Or maybe he just didn't know?

OD: Yeah. Or if they were in *English city/name redacted* away from family pressures, I think a lot of when kind of women feared being rejected it's to do with pressures from, kind of, their significant other's family and things like that?

CO: Well what's really interesting...I've got her wedding photos up at the care home, so I was having a close look at these and there's not a single family member at them – from either side.

OD: Did she have anyone there?

CO: Nobody I recognised. Nobody my cousin in Ireland recognises. So, I dunno whether it was rent-a-crowd or where they came from, but...

OD: Or just friends?

CO: Her mother wasn't there. She had three sisters – they weren't there. None of my dad's brothers or sisters were there.

OD: And are your, kind of, any of your wider family still alive? Or is your mum the oldest?

CO: Well, of that generation she's the last one.

OD: Okay.

CO: Yeah. Which is frustrating.

OD: Yeah. There's a few questions isn't there?

CO: There's quite a few questions, yeah.

OD: So you...we've got these missing years and that's interesting. Okay, so she comes to *English city/name redacted* – gets married in *English city/name redacted*?

CO: Yeah, got married in England. But then they went to Ireland, they had a couple of shops in *Irish city redacted* and that's where I was born.

OD: Oh, okay. So, what kind of shop?

CO: A grocery shop. So that's mostly what she did, shop work.

OD: So was your father – had he already been doing that and then decided to go to *Irish city redacted* or was it just something they...

CO: I don't know. I mean he always said he came over to England with half a crown in his pocket, and he asphalted the roads for years.

OD: Really?

CO: Yeah.

OD: Wow.

CO: Everywhere we went: “Oh yes, I asphalted the roads there.” And then he was a milkman, a barman and then they bought a shop in *location redacted*.

OD: Wow. I mean different time, but that’s pretty nice.

CO: Yeah, yeah. Well, it’s converted now to plush flats, so...I also went to see the place in *name of Irish city redacted* and the shop they had there – that’s...

OD: That’s probably nice flats too now?

CO: No. It’s the wrong side of the city.

OD: Oh, okay. So...wow. So, your dad was just a grafter then? Someone who worked hard?

CO: He was a worker, yeah, yeah.

OD: So, what happens in *the Irish city/name redacted*?

CO: Well, I think they were very settled there. Why they left I don’t know, but I would say probably to try and earn more money. They had three children there. They lived above the shop – maybe they were running out of space or, I don’t know. They didn’t own the shop, they rented it, so that could be the other thing, that it was difficult to pay the rent.

OD: So, you thought you were the third?

CO: Yeah.

OD: Okay, third child. So where did they go after leaving *Irish city redacted*?

CO: England.

OD: Back to England?

CO: So, they went to *location redacted*, and my mum had a couple more children there. So, she had five in six years.

OD: Oh, that's impressive.

CO: Fertile.

OD: Yeah. And did you have a good relationship with your parents?

CO: Yeah, it was all right, yeah.

OD: And they had a good relationship with each other?

CO: Seemed to, yeah. They were married for fifty-odd years., so...

OD: So, I wonder what your dad did know, then?

CO: I don't know. He always used to say "You mustn't upset your mum." He

said that a lot, you know, if there was anything kicking off: “You mustn’t upset your mum.” So that makes me kind of think, did he, did he know?

OD: Or knew something maybe, or...

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Because these communities are quite small aren’t they? They’re quite close-knit, and I should imagine that’s a large part of why these women sort of disappear into these institutions is because of this fear of communities finding out things?

CO: Yeah, that’s true.

OD: So, I wondered if he knew something but not everything?

CO: Yeah. They’re very tight-lipped as well, though. My cousin said: “The Irish never stop talking but they tell you nothing.” I thought it was quite a good way of summing it up.

OD: It’s a good way of understanding these histories, I think. So yeah...so how about your kind of journey to understanding this? What’s been your way of trying to find out more information? And how successful have you been?

CO: Who have I spoken to? So, I contacted Birth Mothers for Justice – a campaign group.

OD: Oh yeah, yeah.

CO: Yeah, you know them?

OD: Yep.

CO: They pointed me to the social worker in Northern Ireland. She was the one that asked for the birth certificate and was the first to suggest that my mum had been in the workhouse. I googled around and found the newspaper clipping...

OD: Oh, and we've got a copy of the newspaper clipping here, which is basically saying that the head – is it the head of the *location redacted* workhouse?

CO: The master of *location redacted* workhouse was the informant on my mum's birth certificate.

OD: Which I think is really significant?

CO: Yeah.

OD: Because...

CO: Normally that would be a relative.

OD: Yeah, exactly.

CO: And the Public Records Office of Northern Ireland confirmed that mum was in the workhouse...

OD: What was your mother's – we'll take it out of the transcript, obviously –

but what was your mother's maiden name?

CO: *surname redacted*

OD: *surname redacted*. So, she would have appeared as *surname redacted*. Okay.

CO: I wrote to Amber Rudd.

OD: Oh really?

CO: Yeah. Didn't get an answer. I also wrote to the Mid-Ulster Council. Northern Ireland Courts and Tribunal Service. I think it must have been them that gave me permission to go to the courthouse.

OD: Yeah. I think you've done...you've kind of covered so many areas...

CO: Yeah.

OD: ...it must have been really hard work to track down?

CO: It was. It was pretty intensive, but I think I got the first email from my cousin in September to alert me to the fact that there might be somebody out there.

OD: Yeah.

CO: And we met in November.

OD: So that's September 20...

CO: 17.

OD: '17. Okay.

CO: So, it felt like it was a long time but I was working on it every evening, and also there was a whole month where I didn't hear from my half-sister. So really all of this happened in about a month.

OD: In sort of a month?

CO: Yeah. Now I did get warned off this research process.

OD: By who?

CO: Should I say that?

OD: Only if you...yeah. You decide.

CO: Well, let me tell you what they said, because I think it's quite important. So, I've written this down:

How some victims feel about this research.

1. The research commissioned by Stormont Department of Health into Magdalene Laundries in Northern Ireland is a stitch-up.
2. The academics are naïve puppets of an attempted government cover-up.

3. A fair process and fair outcomes for victims have been made impossible by a number of procedural issues.
4. The agenda of this group [the victims' group] is 'seeking truth, justice, disclosure, redress and apology'.

So, I'm just saying that we shouldn't forget that there's a lot of birth mothers outside of this research process that are also seeking justice for the abuse suffered in the Magdalene asylums and other institutions just for being unmarried mothers. So, I thought I should just give them a little bit of a voice as well.

OD: Yeah, absolutely. I think it's very...it's such a tricky way to navigate because...

CO: Yeah.

OD: ...you can only work with what your sort of given, can't you?

CO: Yeah. I mean I didn't want to jeopardise anything for them, but I did point out that my mum is ninety-two – I want her to have a voice before she dies.

OD: Yeah.

CO: And they were okay about that.

OD: Okay. So, all these different kind of areas that you went to look for

different, kind of, avenues to find this story out – where was the most successful, do you think?

CO: The Adoption Register. But only because *half-sister's name redacted* had put herself on it ten years previously.

OD: Yeah.

CO: But I was told that...I can't remember who I spoke to? I think it was somebody in one of the family placement centres? She said she'd never heard of anyone finding their relative through it. It's very, very underused.

OD: That's really important. That might be a resource that people aren't aware [of] or aren't utilising.

CO: Yeah. So, without that I think pretty much I was reaching dead ends.

OD: I'm not surprised. And when you send all these letters out, all these emails, these letters – whatever – what's the response rate like?

CO: Oh, I think apart from Amber Rudd I think everybody answered.

OD: And is she your local MP? Is that why you wrote to her, or...

CO: Home Secretary.

OD: So, is there anything in the notes that we haven't covered that you'd like to talk about, 'cos they look really detailed and I'd hate to miss anything?

CO: Mum kept her faith and attended Mass regularly.

OD: Oh really? And...

CO: And somebody told me – again, I think it was this social worker in Northern Ireland – that the women who kept their faith fared much better than those who lost their faith.

OD: Why did she say that? What do you think that's...

[Phone rings]

OD: Oh, go ahead.

CO: Are you sure?

OD: Yep. We can pause, yep.

OD: Okay, so we've just re-started both the recorders. So, you were saying that she kept her faith and she fared better?

CO: Yeah. Mass every Sunday, we had to do the rosary.

OD: Oh, so your whole family kept it?

CO: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Oh, okay. And is that something that's continued through generations, or have you sort of stepped away from it?

CO: Well my older sister – the original older sister – she’s still Catholic and goes to Mass. My new half-sister is a Christian, committed Christian, but not in the Catholic Church.

OD: Right, okay.

CO: I don’t really go to church but I have a belief in God, so...

OD: I think...

CO: ...the others, I’m not sure.

OD: ...that’s really interesting that the social worker said that. That there’s a difference between how successful people were afterwards. And I’m just wondering why that was – if it was more to do with the help that you could receive, or like a personal state of mind, like it was easier to come back from it?

CO: I don’t know.

OD: It’s interesting.

CO: It provides a certain stability, I suppose, and continuity and...

OD: Yeah, and especially if you’re moving in between Ireland and England perhaps it’s a case of...

CO: And if you’ve still got all the guilt and shame it’s a way of, you know, you can carry on going to communion and confession and going through the rituals.

OD: Yeah, that's really interesting. That's...I hadn't thought of that. It might be a way to kind of purge some of the feelings?

CO: It contains, it contains everything doesn't it?

OD: Yeah. That's really interesting. I...I'm going to look into that. Okay.

CO: And maybe the priest, you know, who acted for the adoptive parents, maybe he spoke to her and maybe he was very nice.

OD: Yeah. And I suppose it comes down to how you interact with individuals as well, isn't it? If you have a good experience. Interesting. Great.

CO: And also something about her personality – she always loved the simple things in life, you know, a walk, a visit to the library and tending her garden, which was crammed full of plants. And I always used to say about her that she appreciates that tiny garden infinitely more than people with their millions and their acres.

OD: Reminds me of my mum a lot actually?

CO: Oh really? It's a real gift, actually, just to be able to appreciate the simple things, yeah.

OD: And does she still, does she still kind of have access to those things? Do they still bring her happiness, or...

CO: Well, we wheel her out to the garden at the care home occasionally, but she

makes a fuss.

OD: Okay.

CO: No, she's a little bit past all that unfortunately.

OD: But I think that's a nice, it's nice to be able to recognise that. That even though this happened to her that she was still able to kind of find happiness and that she clearly had it with you and all her successive children after that.

CO: Yeah. Something I have forgotten to tell you, which is significant, because you said the thing about the poorhouse came out of nowhere: her care home is an old workhouse.

OD: Oh no. Oh wow. And did you know that?

CO: Well, yeah, I knew it was an old workhouse, but I didn't know that she'd been in a workhouse.

OD: Of course, yeah.

CO: Yeah.

OD: So is it sort of a...does it look...

CO: It's quite institutional-looking, yeah.

OD: I've seen a couple of old workhouses in, kind of, in Ireland and they don't really lose that look, do they?

CO: No.

OD: Inside can look completely different, but there is still that kind of imposing...

CO: Yeah, it feels institutional. The staff are very nice there. I mean she's feisty and she's illogical and she has an infectious laugh, and the staff are very fond of her – but she has challenging behaviour [laughs].

OD: I think that's...that's to be expected, yeah.

CO: And three years ago we were told she wouldn't last the night, so she's very good at defying the odds.

OD: Oh. And she's ninety-two?

CO: She's ninety-two, yeah.

OD: So, she's very good at defying them.

CO: You know, she is good at defying them but what's happened to her will have left deep scars without a doubt, you know? I think she lost her home and the country she loved.

OD: Yeah.

CO: She, you know, had to endure years of silence due to shame. And the grief at losing her child must be on-going....And wonder about them and, you know, you see it on the television, the *Long Lost Family*, how deeply emotional these

people are and how it never leaves them, you know?

OD: And I think if you get the chance to maybe talk about it slightly earlier you can mitigate that to some extent by trying to, kind of, pursue them or find them or something? But it sounds like your mum had to remain silent for a very long time?

CO: Yeah. I think it's very sad that she wasn't able to tell any of her children either. And it must have affected her relationship with the rest of her children. I can't really begin to speculate about what that meant.

OD: Did you say the oldest child that you thought was the oldest was a girl?

CO: A boy.

OD: A boy, okay. Interesting.

CO: But I remember my cousin saying how ridiculously protective mum was over him. Which, of course, makes sense now.

OD: Yep.

CO: And I have to say that had consequences – which I won't go into – but, you know, it was a bit...it became a bit too symbiotic

OD: I can imagine.

CO: But finding that mum had another child was a shock. We have a good connection with our new half-sister though.

OD: That's really great. I suppose you never know...that's an entirely new kind of presence, that biologically you have that connection, but there's no guarantee that there...that you'll blend well together...

CO: No.

OD: ...or that you'll be able to do that? So, I think it's really amazing that you've got that kind of new relationship and that your mum, although perhaps less able to recognise it, still gets to see that in a way?

CO: Yeah. I think there's a bit of healing that goes on there at some level.

OD: Yeah. I'm glad that your sister...

CO: For both of them.

OD: ...got to meet her even – it's so sad that it's not as simple as kind of a reuniting in a way that maybe would have happened a few years before.

CO: But *half-sister's name redacted* and her husband have come to the care home and sang and played their instruments.

OD: Oh, what do they play?

CO: He plays the *instrument redacted* .

OD: Wow.

CO: And she plays the *instrument redacted*.

OD: Wow. And was she...did she come from a...so she still lives in Ireland, or?

CO: No. I was expecting, when I met her, an Irish accent so I was quite disappointed about that, but she came over to England when...I suppose she must have been somewhere between eighteen and twenty-one, and she did teacher training. But then when she was teaching, she was giving all the children an Irish accent so she...

OD: Had to change...

CO: She had to get rid of it.

OD: Oh wow. That's...oh that breaks my heart. Such a gorgeous accent.

CO: She can still do it.

OD: Yeah, good.

CO: On demand.

OD: Is there anything else you'd like to tell me? I think this had been a fascinating story. I'm really conscious of how excellent your notes are and I really want to make sure that we, we don't lose any of it.

CO: I think I have, probably, covered everything.

OD: Good. And did you say you're happy for us to have, to take the notes with us?

CO: Yes.

OD: Great. Do you have...can I ask you two or three questions that I just ask everyone?

CO: Yeah.

OD: Just sort of in your opinion and obviously I know you're the legal representation – I don't want you to feel like you have to speak for your mother. So, this is sort of based on you: I was just wondering, first of all, why you felt that you wanted to come forward and talk about this? I sort of ask that to everyone regardless of whether it's their story, or their daughter's story, or their mother's story – or however it goes – because I think it's really important to know why people want an inquiry, or why people want this to go further?

CO: Because I think women have been silenced a lot and I wanted my mum to have a voice and knew there wasn't going to be any chance of her doing that. I did actually think long and hard about it because somebody pointed out to me that mum did choose not to tell any of us and...but then I just thought choice doesn't really come into it.

OD: And perhaps they were operating under a different level of...you know, we don't treat women with guilt and shame now?

CO: No.

OD: This isn't something that she's done – it's something that was done to her.

CO: Yeah.

OD: And I think that you're right in that, you know, maybe some women still hold onto those feelings of 'I must keep it silent' or 'I must not tell people' and...

CO: Well even now, in the care home, you know, somebody walks past and she'll say: "Don't tell them anything."

OD: So it sounds like she knows she's got...

CO: She's very...she's quite anxious and she watches everybody. They say she misses nothing even in her sleep.

OD: Wow.

CO: And when the doctor tries to examine her, she'll bat him off and say...what did she say one time? "Stop mauling me and trying to rob me." She doesn't care who they are, they all get the same treatment.

OD: Yeah. But I think...I dunno. I think you're right, it's time that we stopped acting as though the women did something wrong and instead started saying "this is what happened to you then."

CO: And I really hope that this will lead to a public inquiry.

OD: So do I.

CO: Because as far as I'm concerned, there is no doubt that this needs to be properly investigated – but Stormont, you know, shame on them as well. How long have they been out now? [A reference to the suspension of the Northern Ireland Executive between January 2017 and January 2020]

OD: Two years, I think.

CO: Two years. And in those two years how many more women have died? With nothing resolved.

OD: Yeah. I agree. And it is, you know, we're lucky in that a lot of women are still young, you know? We've got women in sort of, seventies, who are able to talk and still able to, kind of, receive some kind of result and we need to recognise that and I think that's really valid. It sort of leads to my next question as well, which is...obviously we hand this information over to the Department of Health and we kind of – will – write the report and everything, and I just wondered what it is that you would want to see from an inquiry should that go ahead? 'Cos I think that, obviously, this project has an archival side to it where we've dug through archives and tried to find, you know, and put forward a story, but we're also trying to physically give women a chance to say what it is that they would want out of that.

CO: Well, first of all, it's my mum and not me.

OD: Yeah.

CO: Secondly, she's ninety-two. So really the only thing that I wanted was to give her a voice, you know There won't be any compensation for her. An apology would mean nothing to her.

OD: Would it mean anything to you?

CO: I don't know. I haven't really thought about it.

OD: And please don't feel like you have to come up with an answer. I just wondered if it was something you had thought about.

CO: The only thing I thought about, you know, in my fantasy world is I came across this statue of a pregnant woman and it was put outside one of the Magdalene laundries.

OD: Yeah.

CO: I can't remember where it was. I remember I put it on my Facebook page, and I thought 'I'd love to do that' and put it in the townland, I think it's called, where she was born. That would be what I'd like to do.

OD: So, to have some kind of commemoration...

CO: Some kind of...

OD: ...or recognition...

CO: Yeah...

OD: ...of them.

CO: Yeah, yeah. That's the only thing that's gone on in my head about it.

OD: That's really lovely. I think that stuff like that, you know, physical demonstrations of acceptance of – and a recognition of...

CO: Yeah, and to remind people that it should never happen again.

OD: Especially, yeah, I suppose as we watch laundries and stuff get converted into flats and things like that, you wonder if, you know, things like that can just sort of remind people of what really went on and they don't let things get forgotten.

CO: I did actually go to the hospital. It's *name redacted*, which is now on the grounds of the old workhouse, and there's one remaining ward – I think it's the old fever ward – which is now *name redacted*, which was the old workhouse. And there's also a plaque put up in *name of road redacted* that a chap in this place, the *location redacted* – told me about? So, I went to look at that.

OD: And is that for the workhouse, or is that for the...

CO: Workhouse.

OD: And does it say anything about women specifically, or is it just...

CO: No, not women specifically, just the residents.

OD: That's interesting.

CO: Or 'All that found refuge' is, I think, the way they put it.

OD: Oh really?

CO: Someone might want to re-write that.

OD: You've given us a lot to think about, like a lot of things...I think because we have less experience interviewing people on workhouses this has given us quite a lot of points that I'd like to consider further, so I really thank you for that.

CO: Oh, you're welcome.

OD: Just things like...

CO: I hope you do...I hope you are able to dig further.

OD: I do as well. If you're happy we'll finish there?

CO: Yeah. That's fine.

OD: I've taken up an hour of your time.

[End of interview].